



A Fascinating Fascination

“The Gadget is an extension of you—because you own it. That’s where “toy” comes from: our toys were our first extensions of ourselves—when we were kids”

COMPUTERS ARE IMPERSONAL—plainly speaking—but there is such a thing as personal technology. So you come to an interesting question: why do gadgets—that is, “personal technological items”—fascinate us the way they do?

Now in case you aren’t aware, go to gadget blog Gizmodo and you’ll see the tagline: “So much in love with shiny new toys, it’s unnatural.” I’m guessing it’s *not* unnatural. Also note that we tend to call them “toys”; it’s not a casual word for lack of something better. Why do we call them toys? And where do those dreamy desires to possess them come from?

Right, so you’re wondering why I’m asking all this. It’s like this: it’s plain that beyond utility, beyond aesthetics, beyond form, beyond function, beyond beauty, beyond all the words associated with gadgets, there’s something so totally irrational about the whole thing, it begs to be grasped. It *must* be grasped, in fact, if you can see how odd it is: so much passion poured into something non-human.

One idea comes from the simple fact that we want to own gadgets, not just see and use and touch them. Yes, we do those things when a friend gets one over, but much stronger is the desire to possess.

Then, here’s Michael Heim, in *The Erotic Ontology of Cyberspace*: “We love the simple, clear-cut linear surfaces that computers generate. We love the way that computers reduce complexity and ambiguity, capturing things in a digital network, clothing them in beaming colors, and girding them with precise geometrical structures.” And

then: “Our love affair with computers... runs deeper than aesthetic fascination and deeper than the play of the senses. We are searching for a home for the mind and heart.”

What you get, then, is this: The Gadget is an extension of you—because you own it. That’s where “toy” comes from: our toys were our first extensions of ourselves—when we were kids. And now, these extensions are mini-universes; being free of apparent complexity, they let us make sense of things. When we use them, we’re navigating a structured universe of our own—which is delight.

This is true for everything digital—computers, connectivity, and everything else—but it rings loud when you think of gadgets. But then, everything is getting smaller, and everything is getting personal anyway: we’ll soon wear them, implant them. “Man-machine convergence” is the obvious thought, but this isn’t the space for that.

Or is it? Let’s see: as *The Matrix* told you, you unknowingly create your own universe: what natural conclusion but that we’ll merge with our machines, seeing as that act will give you the ability to *knowingly* create your own universe?

Our current craze or obsession or love for The Personal Gadget is just the sign of where we’re headed. It won’t forever remain the toy.

It’s vaguely fearsome, I must admit, and I’m wondering what our toys will be at that stage of our technological maturity. (We’re kids now.)

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